

Un-brie-lievable: A cheese-eating Eurasian Oystercatcher *Haematopus ostralegus*

Trevor MacLaurin^{1,2}

¹ Environment and Life Sciences Graduate Program, Trent University, 1600 W Bank Dr., Peterborough, Ontario, Canada. trevormaclaurin@gmail.com

² Department of Ecoscience, Aarhus University, 1110 C. F. Møllers Allé 8, Aarhus, Denmark

Keywords: urban foraging, eating cheese, anthropogenic food, opportunistic feeding, diet

Rapid development, urbanization, and habitat loss have led to drastic increases in human-wildlife interactions (McMahon *et al.* 2024). Novel environments, combined with inaccessibility of traditional resources, may inspire innovative adaptive behaviors (Griffin *et al.* 2017). Examples of such behavioral adaptation are increasingly common. A classic example is that several tit species (Paridae) in the United Kingdom learned to pierce foil caps on milk bottles to access the cream beneath (Fisher & Hinde 1949). A Western Gull *Larus occidentalis* in California, USA, has learned that garbage trucks provide easy transport to a nearby waste facility with an abundance of easily accessible food (Cimino *et al.* 2025). In Australia, Sulphur-crested Cockatoos *Cacatua galerita* have learned how to open garbage bins to exploit them as a novel food source (Klump *et al.* 2021). The ability to learn and adapt to changing environments may be critical for long-term population survival and stability (Møller 2009, Lowry *et al.* 2013, Bateman *et al.* 2020).

The Eurasian Oystercatcher *Haematopus ostralegus* (hereafter Oystercatcher) is facing increased rates of human coexistence (Löffler *et al.* 2024). They began breeding in urban environments in the 20th century (Safriel 1985), and the proportion of urban nesting individuals has gradually increased since then (Ens *et al.* 2011, Wortel *et al.* 2024), necessitating dietary and behavioral shifts. Oystercatchers are adaptive specialists that feed on invertebrates such as Common Cockle *Cerastoderma edule*, Blue Mussel *Mytilus edulis*, marine or terrestrial worms (Polychaeta, Lumbricidae), snails (Gastropoda), or crane flies (Tipulidae; Zwarts *et al.* 1996). They now nest on urban rooftops where they have shown remarkable increases in breeding productivity and have now learned to exploit sports pitches as effective foraging grounds (e.g., Löffler *et al.* 2024). In southern Norway, Eurasian Oystercatchers breeding in the inner section of coastal archipelagos fledged more young than those breeding in the middle or outer sections, despite higher levels of human presence. Breeding success in the inner section appears to result from a combination of favorable environmental conditions and, notably, habituation to predictable, low-risk human activity (Tjørve & Tjørve 2016). Although increasingly well-documented, why such behaviors have begun to occur remains unclear.

Such examples of habitat and foraging flexibility are now being matched by increasingly bold behaviors. In a particularly striking example, van Dijk (2014) describes the recurring case of Oystercatchers in the Netherlands not only consuming bread but also provisioning it to their chicks. Here, I present the first formal description of another striking example of adaptability in Oystercatchers: interannual, recurring consumption of cheese in the Faroe Islands.

The Faroe Islands (62.0079°N, 6.7900°W) is a small archipelago in the North Atlantic Ocean between Iceland and Norway, inhabited by humans since 500 CE (Curtin *et al.* 2021). In October of 2024 I was informed by local ornithologist Jens-Kjeld Jensen of an unusual report involving an Oystercatcher in Tórshavn, the capital city and largest settlement (population of 14,204; Hagstova Føroya 2025), that regularly visited a residential doorstep to request cheese. I was able to visit the residence on 27 July 2025, to observe the behavior.

Upon arrival, the homeowner described daily visits from Oystercatchers between March and August over four consecutive years (beginning in 2022). He first noticed a pair with at least one chick in 2022 and, recalling local stories of Oystercatchers eating cheese, offered them a piece (the exact type of cheese is not known), which they immediately consumed. Since then, one to two adults (often accompanied by fledglings) have returned each year to accept mozzarella (Arla Foods) either from his hand or the ground just outside the front door (within 1 m). The birds typically visited one to three times daily, and if not promptly served, sometimes pecked at the door to attract attention. The homeowner noted a consistent preference for mozzarella over other cheeses (e.g., cheddar will not be consumed) and rejection of alternative foods like mixed nuts or bird seed.

At 16:30 hrs on the day of my visit, an adult Oystercatcher landed with a fledged juvenile on the adjacent rooftop and began calling. The adult soon descended to the front step and waited patiently while the homeowner retrieved mozzarella cheese from his refrigerator. Over approximately 20 minutes, the adult ate multiple small pieces of mozzarella (Fig. 1) and fed several pieces to the juvenile (Fig. 2), which stayed on the rooftop. The adult remained vigilant throughout the feeding session and

flinched at sudden movements or when the homeowner threw the cheese. I did not directly observe handfeeding, but the homeowner showed me a video from 2022.

This is not the first recorded instance of Oystercatchers consuming anthropogenic food (van Dijk 2014), but it appears to be the only formally described phenomenon of interannual, seasonal use of human-source processed food in the wild. Notably, this behavior does not appear to be an isolated case in the Faroe Islands. The homeowner offered cheese because he had already heard of Oystercatchers eating it elsewhere. Further correspondence with Jens-Kjeld Jensen revealed additional accounts, including birds entering homes and heading straight for kitchens or pantries in search of cheese. While many of these stories have circulated anecdotally and remain unverified, there are social-media posts of Oystercatchers eating cheese, with some birds entering homes to be fed cheese, or simply being remarkably tolerant of humans. This behavior is not isolated to the Faroe Islands having been reported in the Netherlands (Ens *et al.* 2011), and Oystercatchers being hand-fed meat has been recorded in Germany (B. Ens pers. comm.).



Fig. 1. Adult Eurasian Oystercatcher about to consume a piece of mozzarella cheese in Tórshavn, Faroe Islands on 27 Jul 2025. (photo: Trevor MacLaurin)



Fig. 2. Adult Eurasian Oystercatcher (left) having fed a piece of mozzarella cheese to its fledged chick (right; about to swallow cheese) in Tórshavn, Faroe Islands on 27 Jul 2025. (photo: Trevor MacLaurin)

As the Oystercatcher(s) involved are not marked, they may be different individuals. However, their regular visits, bold and anticipatory behavior, and the direct feeding of juveniles suggest that this is a breeding pair returning year-after-year. Given that Oystercatchers typically begin breeding at age three or later (Ens *et al.* 1995, 2014), the juveniles observed being provisioned in 2022 are unlikely to be breeding in 2025. Long-term banding of fledglings and adults from local breeding pairs could therefore help assess whether early exposure to anthropogenic food influences future foraging choices.

What makes this case especially compelling is that it involves a shorebird, a group not generally known for frequent or voluntary interactions with humans (with limited exceptions, e.g., Ruddy Turnstone *Arenaria interpres*). Exploitation of anthropogenic food sources is well documented in species such as corvids (e.g., American Crows *Corvus brachyrhynchos* eating cheeseburgers; Townsend *et al.* 2019) or gulls (e.g., Herring Gulls *Larus argentatus* eating doughnuts; Deering 2017), but both taxa are characterized by high cognitive flexibility and urban tolerance (Benmazouz *et al.* 2021, Hacker *et al.* 2023, Goumas *et al.* 2024). In contrast, shorebirds are typically associated with open coasts, wetlands, and estuarine environments, although there are other notable exceptions with some plovers nesting on urban rooftops (Cramp & Simmons 1983, Davis & Armstrong 1997, Baumann 2006, Sethi *et al.* 2011). Oystercatchers approaching a house, and routinely soliciting food, rejecting certain cheeses, and feeding its offspring, contrasts with the general wariness of most other shorebirds.

The ecological and physiological implications of cheese consumption in Oystercatchers are unknown. Cheese is energy dense and offers a high caloric reward relative to effort, which may partly explain its appeal (Walther *et al.* 2008). Some bird conservation organisations suggest that cheese be fed to birds during periods of extreme cold (RSPB 2024). Although cheese has occasionally been used to provision birds in captivity or for research (e.g., small portions in feeding experiments with Canada Jays *Perisoreus canadensis*; Dow 1965), its long-term impact is unknown. Cheese bears little resemblance to the Oystercatcher's typical diet of mollusks and polychaetes. The sustained, multi-year nature of this interaction raises interesting questions about the digestive consequences and potential long-term health effects.

I wrote this short communication with the express permission and encouragement of both local ornithologist Jens-Kjeld Jensen and the homeowner Beinir Nattestad Danielsen. I would like to thank Jens-Kjeld Jensen for introducing me to the weird world of cheese-eating Oystercatchers. I would like to extend a huge thank you to Beinir for his hospitality, enthusiasm, and storytelling. Thank you to Jake Nafziger for fixing my terribly under-exposed photos. Thank you to Anne Ausems for editorial comments and Bruno Ens for extremely helpful and knowledgeable comments.

- Bateman, B.L., C. Wisley, L. Taylor, J. Wu, J.S. LeBaron & G. Langham. 2020. North American birds require mitigation and adaptation to reduce vulnerability to climate change. *Conservation Science & Practice* 2: e242.
- Baumann, N. 2006. Ground-nesting birds on green roofs in Switzerland: preliminary observations. *Urban Habitats* 4: 37–50.
- Benmazouz, I., J. Jokimäki, S. Lengyel, L. Juhász, M.-L. Kaisanlahti-Jokimäki, G. Kardos, P. Paládi & L. Kövér. 2021. Corvids in urban environments: a systematic global literature review. *Animals* 11: 3226.
- Cimino, M.A., H. Welch, P. Warzybok & S.A. Shaffer. 2025. The first GPS observation of a Western Gull (*Larus occidentalis*) riding in a long-haul garbage transfer truck. *Waterbirds* 48: 1–5.
- Cramp, S. & K.E.L. Simmons. (Eds.). 1983. *The birds of the Western Palearctic. Vol. 3: Waders to gulls*. Oxford University Press, Oxford, UK.
- Curtin, L., W.J. D'Andrea, N.L. Balascio, S. Shirazi, B. Shapiro, G.A. de Wet, R.S. Bradley & J. Bakke. 2021. Sedimentary DNA and molecular evidence for early human occupation of the Faroe Islands. *Communications Earth & Environment* 2: 253.
- Davis, W.E., Jr. & C. Armstrong. 1997. Killdeer nest on gravel roofs of office buildings in Canton, Massachusetts. *Bird Observer* 25: 94–98.
- Deering, B. 2017. 'A seagull just stole my doughnut': Humans versus Herring Gulls in the fight for food. *Field Studies* 13: 1–3.
- Dow, D.D. 1965. The role of saliva in food storage by the Gray Jay. *Auk* 82: 139–154.
- Ens, B.J., F.J. Weissing & R. Drent. 1995. The despotic distribution and deferred maturity: two sides of the same coin. *American Naturalist* 146: 625–650.
- Ens, B.J., B. Aarts, C. Hallmann, K. Oosterbeek, H. Sierdsema, R. Slaterus, G. Troost, C. van Turnhout, P. Wiersma, E. van Winden & J. Nienhuis. 2011. *Scholeksters in de knel: onderzoek naar de oorzaken van de dramatische achteruitgang van de Scholekster in Nederland*. SOVON-onderzoeksrapport 2011/13. Sovon Vogelonderzoek, Nijmegen, the Netherlands. [In Dutch]
- Ens, B.J., M. van de Pol & J.D. Goss-Custard. 2014. The study of career decisions: Oystercatchers as social prisoners. Pp. 343–420 in: *Advances in the study of behavior*, Vol. 46 (M. Naguib, S.D. Healy, J.C. Mitani, L.W. Simmons, H.J. Brockmann, T.J. Roper & L. Barrett, Eds.). Academic Press, USA.
- Fisher, J. & R.A. Hinde. 1949. The opening of milk bottles by birds. *British Birds* 42: 347–357.
- Goumas, M., C.R. Berkin, C.W. Rayner & N.J. Boogert. 2024. From the sea to the city: explaining gulls' use of urban habitats. *Frontiers in Ecology & Evolution* 12: 1256911.
- Griffin, A.S., K. Netto & C. Peneaux. 2017. Neophilia, innovation and learning in an urbanized world: a critical evaluation of mixed findings. *Current Opinion in Behavioural Sciences* 16: 15–22.
- Hacker, F., K. Smith & P. Graham. 2023. Inter-species stimulus enhancement: herring gulls (*Larus argentatus*) mimic human food choice during foraging. *Biology Letters* 19: 20230035.
- Hagstova Føroya. 2025. *Population*. Statistics Faroe Islands. Accessed 18 Aug 2024 at: <https://hagstova.fo/en/population/population/population>.
- Klump, B.C., J.M. Martin, S. Wild, J.K. Hörsch, R.E. Major & L.M. Aplin. 2021. Innovation and geographic spread of a complex foraging culture in an urban parrot. *Science* 373: 456–460.
- Löffler, F., J. Brüggeshemke, F.M. Freienstein, S. Kämpfer & T. Fartmann. 2024. Urban rooftops near sports pitches provide a safe haven for a declining shorebird. *Scientific Reports* 14: 9248.
- Lowry, H., A. Lill & B.B.M. Wong. 2013. Behavioural responses of wildlife to urban environments. *Biological Reviews* 88: 537–549.
- McMahon, B.J., B. Arroyo, N. Bunnefeld, M. Carrete, F. Daunt & J.C. Young. 2024. Birds and people: from conflict to coexistence. *Ibis* 166: 23–37.
- Møller, A.P. 2009. Successful city dwellers: a comparative study of the ecological characteristics of urban birds in the Western Palearctic. *Oecologia* 159: 849–858.
- Royal Society for the Protection of Birds (RSPB). 2024. Three ways you can help birds in a cold snap. Accessed 18 Aug 2025 at: <https://www.rspb.org.uk/whats-happening/news/three-ways-you-can-help-birds-in-a-cold-snap>
- Safriel, U.N. 1985. 'Diet dimorphism' within an Oystercatcher *Haematopus ostralegus* population – adaptive significant and effects on recent distribution dynamics. *Ibis* 127: 287–305.
- Sethi, V. K., D. Bhatt, A. Kumar & A. B. Naithani. 2011. The hatching success of ground- and roof-nesting Red-wattled Lapwing *Vanellus indicus* in Haridwar, India. *Forktail* 27: 7–10.
- Tjørve, K.M.C. & E. Tjørve. 2016. The influence of human activity on the breeding success of Eurasian Oystercatchers *Haematopus ostralegus* in southern Norway. *Wader Study* 123: 21–28.
- Townsend, A.K., H.A. Staab & C.M. Barker. 2019. Urbanization and elevated cholesterol in American Crows. *Ornithological Applications* 121: 1–10.
- van Dijk, K. 2014. Notes on the foraging behaviour of Eurasian Oystercatchers *Haematopus ostralegus* feeding on bread. *Wader Study Group Bulletin* 121: 15–17.
- Walther, B., A. Schmid, R. Sieber & K. Wehrmüller. 2008. Cheese in nutrition and health. *Dairy Science & Technology* 88: 389–405.
- Wortel, M., P. van Els, T. Glastra & E. Kleyheeg. 2024. *Resultaten van het jaar van de Scholekster*. Sovon-rapport 2024/44, Sovon Vogelonderzoek, Nijmegen, the Netherlands. [In Dutch]
- Zwarts, L., B.J. Ens, J.D. Goss-Custard, J.B. Hulscher & S.E.A. le V. dit Durell. 1996. Causes of variation in prey profitability and its consequences for the intake rate of the Oystercatcher *Haematopus ostralegus*. *Ardea* 84: 229–268.